to face the many challenges that the company faced. Among them was the scant demand for computers in the country in the initial stages of the company. ‘Computers were not appreciated in the country at that time and that is why we looked for exports,’ said Kohli. But the company leaders were equal to the task.

They steered TCS with little help from Tata Sons, unlike the group’s other traditional enterprises. Consequently, there was neither any need nor reason for the chairman of the group to intervene in the company. TCS was largely ‘self-propelled’, S. Ramadorai, former CEO and MD of TCS elaborates. Kohli, Ramadorai and N. Chandrasekaran, the present chairman of Tata Sons and previously CEO of TCS, made the software giant what it is today.

Under their extraordinary leadership, TCS grew in leaps and bounds bringing the group enormous benefits. Crucially, the surplus the company generated also helped Ratan increase the holdings of Tata Sons in Tata companies, which was critically required to prevent hostile takeovers in the post-liberalization era.

The Ratan Influence

Ratan recognized the contributions of TCS’s technical leaders towards the large strides that the company was making, and understood that there was no requirement for him to be intimately involved in its affairs; neither did he have the technical knowledge to manage its affairs at the operational level. He commented that he had ‘great interest’ in the business, but added, ‘I don’t consider myself to be someone who has my arms around this technology and the person to whom everybody comes to understand what it is. No, not at all.’ His contributions to it were not, however, insignificant. His downplaying of his contributions to TCS is unsurprising, as shying away from taking credit for his achievements is second nature to him. Ratan’s contributions were perhaps less visible in this case as, unlike some of the other group companies which faced existential issues, TCS was a sterling performer. But many of his decisions helped significantly in making TCS what it is today. Notably, soon after Ratan took over as chairman, Tata Sons, he was called upon to take a crucial decision regarding the status of TCS. It came in the form of a proposal that was moved to hive off TCS from Tata Sons and make it a separate corporate entity.